3

Domesticity and modernization

In May 1940, a smartly dressed African American woman from Winston-Salem, North Carolina disembarked at Cape Town harbor. The war in Europe had postponed her trip to South Africa and her upcoming marriage to A.B. Xuma, a highly respected physician who was soon to become President of the African National Congress (ANC), the country's main nationalist organization. Well-educated and anxious to contribute her experience to the cause of black progress in her adopted country, Madie Hall Xuma revitalized the ANC Women's League and became its first President. But equally important, she founded a network of women's organizations, the Zenzele ("do it yourself") clubs. With a strongly domestic focus during the 1940s and a greater emphasis on social service after their affiliation with the international YWCA in the 1950s, these clubs formed the center of Xuma's life in South Africa, creating the legacy most commonly attached to her name.

In an interview in 1963, just before Hall left South Africa after her husband's death, she elaborated on how she perceived domestic skills:

> In the past twenty years there has been a wonderful change in African homes, despite the low income. The women can prepare meals and entertain with confidence and they often do so. High teas, morning teas, luncheons etc. are prepared by them and served beautifully. They have also learnt how to dress, with right colour combinations,

https://doi.org/10.1017/CBO9780511979972.006 Published online by Cambridge University Press

> and how to sit, stand and walk correctly. When buying furniture for their tiny homes, they choose carefully, giving attention to design and colour.[1]

Although the Zenzele clubs conveyed new domestic expertise and ideas about gracious living, Hall stressed the longer-term personal significance of these accomplishments. The clubs, she believed, gave women enhanced confidence and knowledge of how to run an organization and raise funds, and a new collective identity as sophisticated homemakers.

Women's accounts of their activities best convey the meaning of this experience. In 1947, R. Msweli, a founding member, wrote from the Johannesburg neighborhood of Sophiatown about her new level of self-assurance:

> The development the Club has roused in me could be the following:- (i) It has improved me socially and mentally (ii) It has removed inferiority complex in my person (iii) It has taught me to work cooperatively (iv) It has enable [sic] me to depend on myself regarding home management.[2]

While Zenzele groups emphasized domestic themes in the 1940s, Xuma denied that this concentration restricted women to the home. Perceiving these domestic accomplishments as the mark of modern womanhood, she argued that domesticity enhanced women's lives and those of their families and friends by adding new skills and expertise to the tasks they already performed. These skills, she argued, were markers of class, culture, and respectability that she shared with South African women, thereby "lifting" them to her own level of refinement.

Xuma's interpretation of the politics of domesticity and respectability helps to explain the gender ideologies that became increasingly important during the late 1940s and 1950s. By embracing a culture centered on home life and refinement, African women could earn admiration as modern and respectable, thereby striking back at the colonial discourses pervasive in the prewar period that branded them as purveyors of sin and immorality. These negative images persisted, particularly in the settler societies of southern Africa, in response to

[1] Quoted in Iris Berger, "An African American 'Mother of the Nation': Madie Hall Xuma in South Africa, 1940–1963, *Journal of Southern African Studies* 27, 3 (September 2001), 560.

[2] From Berger, "African American 'Mother of the Nation,'" 561.

https://doi.org/10.1017/CBO9780511979972.006 Published online by Cambridge University Press

a surge of women migrants to major cities during and after the War. Yet embracing a European domestic ideology as a means of empowerment also had adverse consequences, particularly when enshrined and reproduced in educational systems that offered gender-specific, second-class schooling to girls.

The Second World War accelerated political and social change throughout the African continent. With the former colonial powers devastated on their own soil, and nationalist movements and cold war rivalries putting colonial rulers on the defensive, new attitudes toward the colonial project came to the fore. In an era sometimes referred to as the "Second Colonial Occupation," European rulers made new efforts to invest in their colonies. This ideology of development and modernization brought more intensive and deliberate intervention in local economies, often in the form of programs to "modernize" agriculture that operated to the detriment of women. Assuming that men should be the primary farmers and ignoring women's central role in food production, instructors trained men in new forms of cultivation. Colonial states also began to take greater responsibility for welfare and educational programs once primarily the work of missionaries; these programs were popular with many women, but they also shared the emphasis of their religious predecessors on marriage, motherhood, and domestic capabilities.

As larger numbers of women moved to cities during the postwar period, the urban demographic imbalance began to shift to more equal proportions of women and men. To colonial authorities, particularly in the white settler colonies of southern Africa, this process triggered the alarming associations of urban women with prostitution, venereal disease, adultery, alcoholism, divorce, and high rates of illegitimate births that were established during the prewar years. Many officials included greater female independence and the growing number of women-headed families on their list of moral and social ills. Most firmly dedicated to keeping women out of the major cities, South African officials in the 1950s labeled urban women as "superfluous appendages" of male workers who had the legal right to work in urban areas. Yet, in a trend that went back to the 1920s, African women also took pains to construct their own systems of respectability and propriety, based on learning European cooking, hygiene, sewing and knitting, and leading exemplary lives. In Harare (then Salisbury), for example, being properly married – women for whom *lobolo* (bridewealth) had been paid – was also a primary marker of respectability.

https://doi.org/10.1017/CBO9780511979972.006 Published online by Cambridge University Press

In response to fears of urban women, some governments turned both to educational efforts to alter the moral and social conditions of women's lives and to legal restrictions on their residence in towns. The government of Zambia tried to insure that occupants of African housing had legally registered marriages, while South Africa in the 1950s took the first steps toward extending the pass laws to women, initiating the most stringent controls on their movement anywhere on the continent. According to 1945 legislation in the Congo, officials were required to refuse travel permits to wives and minor daughters who did not have a husband's or father's permission to move to the cities.

But women migrants also became more common in most cities. By the 1940s in Harare larger numbers of women became "migrant wives." These women lived with their husbands in town, but returned regularly to rural areas (which they identified as "home") to plant, weed, and harvest their crops. To some women, spending time living with their husbands in town became a defense against their husbands' developing *maputo* (temporary marriage) relationships with other women. Mrs Maria Chagaresango, who moved to Harare in 1945 explained:

> [After marriage I didn't stay in town.] I would just come and go back home [in the reserve]. I would come occasionally … I would come when there was not work at home. During the plowing season I would be at home … Later on with the coming of schools the women would stay [in town] with their children who were going to school here. But when it was time for work [in the reserves] I would just leave the children with their father.[3]

During these critical postwar decades, European intervention in African life and local responses to social transformation followed many patterns established earlier in the century. Both colonial officials and missionaries continued and sometimes intensified their efforts to transform rites of passage and marriage practices and to medicalize childbirth. Similarly, women still fled to towns and cities to avoid arranged marriages, adopted new cash crops and farming techniques, and sought out innovative forms of

[3] Quoted in Teresa A. Barnes, "*We Women Worked So Hard": Gender, Urbanization, and Social Reproduction in Colonial Harare, Zimbabwe, 1930–1956* (Portsmouth, NH: Heinemann, 1999), 115.

https://doi.org/10.1017/CBO9780511979972.006 Published online by Cambridge University Press

religious expression. They also took up new urban occupations – as petty traders, domestic workers, and sex workers. But with the expansion of Western schools in most colonies, the number of educated young women climbed (though unevenly) throughout the continent. Expanded educational programs intensified the cultural and economic divisions among women and contributed to spreading a modernized women's culture to cities and towns. In this new context, many "traditional" practices such as bridewealth and polygyny became topics of heated debate not simply between Europeans and Africans, but among Africans with different attitudes toward local customs.

Education and domesticity

As part of the effort to promote the "advancement" of African women and to supply a growing male elite with suitably trained wives, colonial states began to take a more active role in promoting girls' education, although one that varied greatly from one colony to the next. The number of girls attending school increased rapidly in some areas; but boys continued to outnumber them by a substantial margin. As in the past, these efforts at female education combined academic subjects with a heavy emphasis on domestic science. Formal instruction was matched by a vast network of official and voluntary programs designed to promote women's "domestication" on a European model. In both urban and rural areas, instructors in these projects taught basic literacy and math, along with cooking, sewing, health, hygiene, and childcare. Whether initiated and promoted by women's clubs in Tanzania and South Africa, the Maendeleo ya Wanawake (Women's Progress) movement throughout Kenya, "improvement associations" in the coastal city of Mombasa, *foyers sociaux* (housekeeping schools) in Bujumbura (Burundi), mining companies in Zambia, or the Women's Corona Society in British Cameroon all conveyed a morally charged message emphasizing women's primary place in the home and family. (See Figure 2.)

The Belgian Congo illustrates the ambiguous impact of colonial education on women. As in many other parts of the continent, education was the sphere of missionaries, especially of the Catholic Church. Boys received instruction in French, girls (smaller in number

https://doi.org/10.1017/CBO9780511979972.006 Published online by Cambridge University Press



FIGURE 2 Women doing needlework in Kumba, the largest town in south-west Cameroon. Needlework was very popular among the domestic science subjects taught to African girls and women, along with household sewing and dressmaking, cookery, housekeeping, and maternal hygiene. Despite the limitations of this curriculum, women often learned valuable skills that provided them with independent sources of income.
Source: imageBROKER/Alamy.

as students) in indigenous languages with a focus on homemaking skills. During the interwar period, these men became the first group of *évolués* (meaning "evolved" or "developed," applied to those who emulated European values and behavior) in the colony. After the war, through the influential publication *La Voix du Congolais* (*The Voice of the Congolese*), the members of this all-male group, who aspired to be as much like whites as possible, also expressed influential views about the position of women, in the process articulating a new model of gender relations.

At first, according to both colonizers and missionaries, the purpose of school was to turn boys into artisans and girls into Western, Christian mothers and wives. A set of reforms introduced in 1948 lengthened the period of study for both boys and girls and was intended to prepare a small number of boys for professional positions and postsecondary study. Girls, trained only by nuns, would receive a practical, moral education, still aimed at making them better wives and

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household managers, but also prompting a few to become teachers, nurses, nursing assistants, and midwives. Girls' instruction in French (the colonial language) was minimized, except at the secondary level and courses focused on housekeeping, flower arranging, laundering, ironing, sewing, fieldwork, and cooking – as well as on home furnishing and window decoration. One Congolese nun expressed the view that educating a woman pulls "her out of her semi-servile state, permits her to respond to women's eternal calling in veritably every human society, which is not only to give birth to, but also to raise, men."[4]

The *évolués* justified their claims to superiority over other Congolese by pointing to their monogamous families and to women's domesticated position, using *La Voix du Congolais* to articulate their views on gender relationships. One article explained that, although men clamored for French instruction for their daughters, they were not advocating women's emancipation or gender equity. Another argued that they did not want their wives to acquire knowledge that would place them "at a level which is not naturally reserved to them," but wished only that their wives "be brought closer to our degree of evolution and understand us."[5] Still another explained the importance of teaching girls household skills. "If domestic work isn't accomplished with orderliness and cleanliness, a man won't stay at home."[6] The belief of these men that women should not work outside the home was reinforced by legislation that placed women under male guardianship and required a husband's authorization to allow a wife to work.

In the Congo and elsewhere, cultural questions related to marriage and family life were hotly debated during the 1940s and 1950s. But in the Congo, the *évolué* position on marriage was unequivocal – that polygamy and matrilineal succession in kin relationships were un-Christian, exploited black women, and should be abolished. According to one writer, "A married woman must not be under her brother's [authority]. She must belong to her husband, author of the home that he founded with his wife."[7] This group did not favor eliminating bridewealth, however, but did support drastically reducing

[4] Gertrude Mianda, "Colonialism, Education, and Gender Relations in the Belgian Congo: The Évolué Case," in *Women in Colonial African Histories*, eds Jean Allman, Susan Geiger, and Nakanyike Musisi (Bloomington: Indiana University Press, 2002), 147.

[5] Mianda, "Colonialism," 149.

[6] Mianda, "Colonialism," 150.

[7] Mianda, "Colonialism," 154.

https://doi.org/10.1017/CBO9780511979972.006 Published online by Cambridge University Press

its cost – part of the strategy of rejecting customs they regarded as "primitive," while retaining those that safeguarded men's authority over women.

Homemaking schools and social centers run by Catholic missionaries reinforced instruction in domesticity, promoting practices that were considered the signs of "civilized" status, teaching women appropriate dress, cooking skills, and interior decoration, and training them to serve family meals at the dining table. Because of the association of Western ideas of domestic life with modernity and respectability, some women were pleased with the skills they learned. According to one woman:

> I learned many new things at the social center, but what interested me was the way to raise and educate children, to put a cloth on the table, and to eat at the table with my husband and all our children … I was enchanted with that. Because a woman who maintains her home well and accomplishes all the duties of a homemaker honors her position.[8]

Not all women believed that men were living up to the expectations of "civilization," however. In the first article by a woman in *La Voix du Congolais*, Louise Efolio wrote:

> We can say that many of our men have not yet acquired anything of true civilization, as meant by the Europeans. We will admit that a man is civilized when he gives proof of a true evolution, when he abstains from the irregular maintenance of two or three women, and when he no longer frivolously dissipates money which is indispensable for the maintenance of his household. If men want to imitate whites, they'd better do a good job of it.[9]

In Portuguese-ruled Mozambique, where few girls received a Western education and even fewer postprimary schooling, some girls greatly valued the benefits they received. Even when girls were officially enrolled in school, however, they attended for fewer hours than boys and were often required to stay home to work in their families' fields or to care for younger children. Unlike South Africa in the 1920s and 1930s, where there was ambiguity about whether girls were being trained in domestic skills to use in their own homes or

[8] Mianda, "Colonialism," 156.
[9] Mianda, "Colonialism," 157.

https://doi.org/10.1017/CBO9780511979972.006 Published online by Cambridge University Press

as household workers, the majority of domestic workers in colonial Mozambique were men. In keeping with the tiny number of women who advanced beyond primary school, only a very small number of African women became nurses or teachers. According to the 1960 census, for example, of 115 African primary school teachers, only four were women. Given this emphasis (and the dearth of formal jobs for women during the 1940s and 1950s), it was rare for women to work for a wage. The scarcity of schooling is apparent in the literacy figures. According to the 1970 census, the last before independence in 1975, 93 percent of Mozambican women and 86 percent of men were illiterate in Portuguese.

Muslim areas did not escape the postwar eagerness to educate African girls. Before British colonizers introduced secular education, most young girls on the Swahili coast of east Africa received some religious instruction from a trusted male relative or family friend or from an educated woman, learning the proper way to pray, recite the Quran, and to perform other religious obligations. When controversy erupted over the question of girls' education during the 1930s, prominent Muslim clerics defended the practice of girls' schooling, provided it was not a trap to convert them to Christianity. In 1931, Sheikh al-Amin argued:

> The Prophet himself says that women and men both should be educated. In fact educating one woman is worth educating ten men, because she passes on her good character to her children … Also, a man should take pleasure in his wife's betterment. The Prophet says that better than worldly comfort is a good wife. If she is a fool, she will not know how to make a happy house for him, or know the rights of her husband.[10]

When the Government Arab Girls' School opened in Mombasa in 1938, more than a decade after a similar school for boys, the curriculum included domestic science, Arabic, and Swahili alongside other subjects. Only in the 1950s, however, did girls' education take off, in part to address fears, also expressed elsewhere, that educated men would want wives with comparable learning. The British head of the school, Sylvia Gray, took pains to communicate with parents, to include religious and Quranic studies in the curriculum, and to respond to family

[10] Margaret Strobel, *Muslim Women in Mombasa, 1890–1975* (New Haven: Yale University Press, 1979), 105–06.

https://doi.org/10.1017/CBO9780511979972.006 Published online by Cambridge University Press

concerns, although her efforts at diplomacy did not prevent heated controversy when the hula hoop was introduced to vary the physical education curriculum. Despite quadrupling of the school's population between 1952 and 1962, from 220 students to 880, nearly 70 percent of Swahili girls still received no secular education in the year prior to Kenya's independence. Nonetheless, continuing seclusion provided an additional rationale for women's education – to fill the demand for female doctors, teachers, and midwives.

In British-ruled Zanzibar, an island off the coast of Tanzania then ruled separately from the mainland, girls' education was equally controversial. As in Mombasa, parents in Zanzibar demanded that schools uphold the laws of *purdah* (female seclusion) and into the 1940s gave priority to domestic science, fearing that teaching girls to write would ruin their reputations. Reading and oral performance were less suspect, however, since memorizing and reciting the Quran in Arabic was the basis of Islamic education for girls as well as for boys. Muna, who came of age in the 1950s, explained that her father agreed to let her attend the government school only after she had demonstrated her ability to recite the Quran – a skill that established a young woman's proper religious upbringing. Similarly, following the practice of religious recitation, the secular classroom also emphasized singing and storytelling. As Muna explained, "Whatever we read in the book we dramatized."[11]

Despite fears that teaching girls to write would ruin their reputations, former students found learning to read, speak, and write in Swahili, English, and Arabic as the most critical aspect of their education. During the 1930s and 1940s literacy underpinned their self-perception as "modern girls," and by the 1950s and early 1960s, "the time of politics," as participants in the social and political transformation of the island. Thus, while debates about girls' education centered on the issue of *heshima* ("honor"), schoolgirls reshaped the definitions of the concept to suit their own "modern" forms of respectability.

If elders accepted reading and speaking as integral to girls' schooling, writing was suspect for fear that, if girls learned to write, they would send love letters to boys. Jamila, who enrolled at a rural school

[11] Quoted in Corrie Decker, "Reading, Writing, and Respectability: How Schoolgirls Developed Modern Literacies in Colonial Zanzibar," *International Journal of African Historical Studies* 43, 1 (2010), 100.

https://doi.org/10.1017/CBO9780511979972.006 Published online by Cambridge University Press

on the island of Pemba in the 1940s, characterized her defiance of her parents in the act of writing. Although her family did not wish to send her to school, she enrolled on her own, recalling, "I sent myself, I wrote my name and I stayed [at school] … by myself."[12] At the heart of these anxieties was the link between literacy and puberty – the time when girls ended their Quranic education and were separated from boys. Before the Second World War, many parents removed their daughters from government schools to prepare them for marriage. But by the 1940s, following a new mandate from the British Colonial Office, education officials began to embrace more widespread education for girls as well as for boys. By the time of the revolution in 1964, when the Sultan of Zanzibar was overthrown and the island united with Tanganyika (becoming the new country of Tanzania), girls were expected to reject *purdah* and universal education was embraced as a key aspect of the socialist development agenda.

Cultural collisions: education and its reverberations

As Western education became more widespread, its implications resonated throughout African societies, affecting all stages of women's lives, with consequences for both women and men. Although in most situations African women welcomed the opportunity to become more "modern" and "respectable," the meaning of these concepts was hotly debated and the question of whether being "modern" meant forgoing established cultural practices would continue to provoke controversy throughout the century. By contrast with the early colonial period, however, the lines now were less likely to be drawn between outsiders and African communities than between Africans with different interests, perspectives, and cultural backgrounds. But the challenge of Western ideas to longstanding beliefs about marriage, courtship, and coming-of-age ceremonies was no less fraught in the postwar period than in the early years of the twentieth century.

One dramatic illustration of these tensions occurred in the mid-1950s in the Meru area of central Kenya. After local African officials (all of them male) banned genital cutting in 1956, adolescent girls sought to initiate their own transformation into womanhood

[12] From Decker, "Reading, Writing," 102.

https://doi.org/10.1017/CBO9780511979972.006 Published online by Cambridge University Press

by attempting to excise each other. Using razor blades in place of special-purpose knives, and abandoning the public celebrations normally associated with this rite of passage, these girls exerted peer pressure throughout the district to encourage others to join them, sometimes with the collusion of their mothers and grandmothers. Occurring at the time of the violent "Mau Mau" insurgency against the British government, the girls involved saw their observance of traditional ceremonies as a means of expressing their solidarity with the freedom fighters who were being tortured and killed in the anti-colonial struggle.

More widespread education for girls also had important intergenerational implications, particularly where educated young women might command higher bridewealth gifts when they married. In the Maragoli area of western Kenya, widows were able to take advantage of this prospect, though sometimes with unanticipated consequences. During the Second World War, the region's high population had led colonial officials to recruit large numbers of Maragoli men as forced laborers and soldiers. Not surprisingly, their death rates were high and the number of widows increased. In order to survive, these widows began to place greater value on educating their daughters, encouraging them not only to learn to read and write, but to study home economics so that they might become respectable wives for the newly emerging generation of educated men. Elima Visru, widowed in the 1940s, explained:

> I sent my younger daughter to school because the missionaries taught her good manners. Because my daughter was clever and a good house-worker, I knew she would make a good wife and would draw on the teachings of the missionary education to fear and respect her husband. Education turned young girls into *omugosi* [docile] young women. And respectable men like to marry and pay high dowries for such women.[13]

The investment was a wise one. Bridewealth payments, now generally in cash rather than in livestock, more than tripled during the 1940s, despite the strenuous efforts of colonial administrators to limit them. These official efforts failed because well-paid young soldiers

[13] Kenda Mutongi, "Widowed Mothers, Daughters & Masculinities in Maragoli, Western Kenya, 1940–60," in *Readings in Gender in Africa*, ed. Andrea Cornwall (Bloomington: Indiana University Press, 2005), 73.

https://doi.org/10.1017/CBO9780511979972.006 Published online by Cambridge University Press

could at the same time impress prospective brides with their cash and fulfill the ideals of Maragoli masculinity by helping widows to meet their economic and social needs.

What seemed like an ideal solution for both widows and conscripted men also had its downside, however. When men returned to their duties, some of their young wives began to have love affairs with other men. Although widowed mothers felt responsible for controlling their daughters' conduct, they lacked the authority to do so without a man to enforce discipline. Janet Kaveya, widowed in 1942, described her difficulties in controlling her daughter:

> It was hard when your husband died because you were left alone and, sometimes, people and, even, your own children took you for granted. But during the Italian War [World War II], even the married daughters became very hard to discipline, for they had loose manners with men. If your husband was alive … your daughters obeyed your rules and behaved themselves around men because they knew that if they did not, their father would discipline them.[14]

Indeed, young women's free sexual behavior became so pronounced that complaints about women running away dominated district annual reports in 1942. When men returned, knowledge of their wives' independence and infidelity strained their marriages and contributed to incidences of wife-beating. In such cases, widowed mothers were sometimes compelled to go to the African courts, an unfamiliar and threatening public space, to defend their daughters from abusive husbands.

Cases of domestic violence came to court more frequently after the mid 1940s, when colonial reforms made the courts accessible to women for the first time. The young women and widows who initiated these cases intended only to force the men to stop beating their wives, counting on the public humiliation of a trial to encourage the men to recommit themselves to the marriage. (Divorce would have benefitted neither the widows nor their daughters.) In cases of extreme brutality, however, mothers were willing to sacrifice honor and respectability to save their daughters' lives. Unlike the situation in many parts of southern Africa, where the colonial judicial system generally reflected the interests of elder men, these Maragoli women were able to use the

[14] Mutongi, "Widowed Mothers," 75.

https://doi.org/10.1017/CBO9780511979972.006 Published online by Cambridge University Press

courts both to control their daughters and to regulate the behavior of younger men.

Despite its widespread popularity in the postwar period, Western education also may have caused deep social and psychological distress to many girls and women. In her moving novel Zimbabwean writer Tsitsi Dangarembga explores the "nervous conditions" of the two main characters. Tambudzai is desperate for the European education she is able to receive only after her brother dies, yet she grapples with the resulting alienation she feels from her poor, more traditional rural family. Her cousin Nyasha is anorexic and in intense conflict with her headmaster father who embodies both a deeply traditional patriarchal authority and the "Englishness" at the root of the girls' struggle. When Tambudzai receives a scholarship to attend a prestigious secondary school, her rural mother confronts her:

> Tell me, my daughter, what will I, your mother say to you when you come home a stranger full of white ways and ideas? It will be English, English all the time. He-e, Mummy this, he-e, Mummy that. Like that cousin of yours … I've had enough, I tell you, I've had enough of that man dividing me from my children … If I were a witch I would enfeeble his mind … and then we would see how his education and his money helped him.[15]

The life of "Lily Moya," a pseudonym for a young South African woman, reflected similar conflicts over colonial education, sexuality, and estrangement from her family. In the late 1940s, Lily escaped from the prospect of an arranged marriage to an older man, traveling alone to the east coast city of Durban in a desperate struggle to continue her education. She showed great spunk and determination in enlisting the support of a liberal white benefactor, Mabel Palmer, who helped her get into Natal's top secondary school. But her isolation from her family, her alienation from the other students as the only girl in her class, and Palmer's inability to be the "mother" Lily needed soon overwhelmed her. In her final letter to Mabel Palmer, Lily wrote of her distress:

> For congenial reasons I had to leave Adams, [the school she had attended] due to the fact that I was never meant to be a stone but a human being with feelings, not either an experimental doll.

[15] Tsitsi Dangarembga, *Nervous Conditions: A Novel* (Seattle: Seal Press), 1988, 184.

https://doi.org/10.1017/CBO9780511979972.006 Published online by Cambridge University Press

> …
> About Adams. I think in December 1950, if your memory is still good, I told you that I didn't want staying … You refused … and I stayed there in Adams … not according to my will. I didn't want staying there. You arranged that at my back … I have no news. I'm very ill.[16]

When historian Shula Marks tracked down Lily and her family in the 1980s, she had spent twenty-five years in mental hospitals after visits to local healers failed to cure her distress. She was confined first at Sterkfontein, one of the few institutions for Africans, and then at Randfontein, a hospital for chronically ill psychiatric patients. Then about fifty, and heavily medicated, Lily was barely able to speak English, and had survived the appalling conditions for black patients in these hospitals: lack of bedding, inadequate clothing, overcrowded wards, filthy sanitary facilities – often with bucket toilets, and inedible food. An article in the South African newspaper, the *Sunday Times* described these institutions: "The number of these human warehouses where care is reduced to a minimum and cure a forgotten word is growing year by year – as are the profits of the company which now has such a monopoly on madness that as one authority told me, 'it can virtually dictate mental health care in South Africa.'"[17]

Debates about "tradition"

South African publications aimed at "modernized" urban communities were deeply involved in creating new gendered images of respectability and in debating issues relating to women's position and family life. Their advertising and advice columns shaped new forms of black consumerism, conveying powerful messages that equated "progress" and modernism with stylish Western clothing, hair-straightening and skin-lightening creams, soaps and detergents, deodorants, sanitary napkins, blood-strengthening pills, correspondence schools, and cereals. The combination of advertising and the women's pages of these

[16] Shula Marks, ed., *Not Either an Experimental Doll: The Separate Worlds of Three South African Women* (London: The Women's Press, 1987), 185–86.

[17] From Tiffany Fawn Jones, *Psychiatry, Mental Institutions, and the Mad in Apartheid South Africa* (New York: Routledge, 2012), 149.

https://doi.org/10.1017/CBO9780511979972.006 Published online by Cambridge University Press

publications served to define "female interest" in terms of what to wear and on how to furnish a home, put on make-up, cook proper meals, and raise well-nourished families. In the long term and less obviously, they constructed new images of social status, defining and justifying women's domestic role and presenting stereotyped black women who aspired to the values of white suburban housewives. It was hardly coincidental that the prevalence of these images emphasizing domesticity, respectability, and motherhood coincided with growing concern about black women's independence. Such advertisements also underscored the growing number of middle-class black women living in South Africa's segregated urban townships.

Men's ambivalence about women's equality was reflected in heated controversy over customary marriage practices in magazines directed at urbanized Africans literate in English. In the early 1950s, the South African magazine *Zonk* generated discussion among readers with articles on bridewealth: "Lobola: Is it Right, or Is It Wrong?" and "Lobola: For and Against." Opinions varied – and not necessarily with the gender of the writer. While some readers believed it to be one of the "beautiful traditions" of African culture or a "sacred and respected" transaction, others felt it symbolized a woman's possession and subservience, making her akin to her husband's cattle. The writer concluded, "To the fire with Lobolo!" Another deemed it "a social menace."[18] *Bantu World*, on the other hand, published a letter condemning the *tsotsis* (thugs) who criticized *lobola* as part of their desire to get everything for nothing. "Lobola to them is disastrous, because they cannot afford ONE beast." Yet, since anything obtained for nothing is valueless, "I hope you ladies will heed this grave warning."[19]

Debates on polygamy, *Drum* magazine's discussion topic for December 1955, generated similarly intense disagreement. The winner of the question "Should Polygamy Be Allowed?" argued that although Adam had twenty-four ribs, God made one wife for him – thus proving that having multiple wives was a "social evil." The second-prize winner dissented with a more practical argument – that polygamy gave barren wives company when their husbands were away and help in times of illness; given the number of illegitimate children, perhaps it was ordained by nature. Interestingly, William Ngakane, a pioneering black social worker, then a field worker for the South

[18] *Zonk*, May, June, and July, 1952.
[19] *Bantu World*, August 20, 1995.

https://doi.org/10.1017/CBO9780511979972.006 Published online by Cambridge University Press

African Institute of Race Relations, argued forcefully, "Man is a polygamous animal and any attempt to change him is against nature." Mr G.D. Pewa, a librarian and teacher, took a decidedly more feminist perspective, arguing that polygamy was associated with a marked inferiority in women's status.[20]

Religion and healing

During the late colonial period African-initiated churches remained important avenues for women's spiritual expression and leadership. In an era that stressed marriage and home life as the source of respectability and modernity, the churches assumed particular importance for women whose ambiguous social position – as single, childless, older, or widowed – made them vulnerable. Although some leaders and active members still emerged from among women with spiritual power rooted in earlier religious and healing practices, this was also a period of transition. Mirroring their growing political prominence, educated young men were beginning to usurp women's position, setting a trend that would become more pronounced after independence.

In the Roho Church in western Kenya, which broke from the Anglican Church and expanded aggressively between 1935 and the mid 1950s, charismatic fervor tended to transcend restrictions of age and gender and women maintained their prominent position. In these years, they were free to hold leadership positions and to take long and arduous journeys, often traveling for seven or eight months, to proselytize. Small numbers of women never married, opting instead to devote themselves fully to the church and to live in Christian communes that welcomed single, divorced, and widowed converts. Esta Songa, who worked as a Roho missionary for ten years before agreeing to marry, explained her decision: "People really laughed at me. But I said that I must do as I had promised … The spirit had found me when I was young and I could have married earlier. But if [the Spirit] gets you, then you must do what it arranges."[21] Both women and men became teachers, healers, catechists, and pastors; pastors' wives

[20] *Drum*, December 1955.

[21] Cynthia Hoehler-Fatton, *Women of Fire & Spirit: History, Faith, and Gender in Roho Religion in Western Kenya* (New York: Oxford University Press, 1996), 104.

https://doi.org/10.1017/CBO9780511979972.006 Published online by Cambridge University Press

were empowered to perform all his duties when their husband was away and to assume full religious responsibility after his death. When women became grandmothers, their renown as healers increased, a reflection of Luo assumptions, shared in most African societies, about the mystical powers of older women.

Oral traditions of the movement portrayed the founding women as strong-willed and defiant, challenging colonial characterizations of them as ignorant, hysterical, "lusty wenches." Elderly women recalled their attraction to a religion that allowed them freedom to preach, forbidden in mission churches at the time. They also remembered suffering beatings from their menfolk for attending Roho meetings. Hymns such as "We Are Women of War" kept alive the memory of women's important role in founding the church, celebrating their courage as *askeche* (soldiers) in the violent encounter in which the Roho founder and others were burned to death in their house. One hymn reflected this militancy:

(We are women of war, we are women of fire;)
…
(We are women of victory, we are women of spears;)
…
(We will be happy, we will be happy in heaven!)[22]

On the west coast women initiated important Christian-inspired religious movements devoted to healing women, eradicating witchcraft, and sometimes to challenging local practices burdensome to women. In Côte d'Ivoire, Marie Lalou, a childless woman, was viewed with great suspicion after the deaths of her husband and his brother – whom she had refused to marry following local custom. Returning to the village of her birth, she began to preach that God wanted people to stop harming their neighbors through poisoning and witchcraft, but she had to flee once again when she was blamed for deaths in the village. Finally, in 1942 Lalou established the Deima Church that focused on healing people with holy water, attracting the suspicion of the colonial administration as the church became more popular.

In 1951, shortly after the movement began to grow dramatically, Lalou became ill. Before dying she commanded her followers to use only her holy water for healing and not to force widows into another

[22] Hoehler-Fatton, *Women of Fire & Spirit*, 103.

https://doi.org/10.1017/CBO9780511979972.006 Published online by Cambridge University Press

marriage against their will. One of her successors, Blé Nahi, after receiving a vision from God became known as Jesus Onoï, "woman in the service of God on earth." Both women were considered misfits because they did not have children and were accused of using witchcraft for making their husbands ill or killing them; and both women had visions suggesting that their inability to fill customary women's roles was a sign that God had chosen them for a more exalted position. Blé Nahi was one of a series of important prophetesses who continued Lalou's focus on healing; by the 1970s, however, men held the official positions, directing worship services and controlling administration.

Founded by Grace Tani, the Church of the Twelve Apostles in southwestern Ghana focused its ideology on "bringing into the open" spiritual influences linked to sources of illness – especially women's reproductive capacities, misfortunes in trade, the work of witches, mental "disorders," and general family issues. With rituals very similar to those of earlier religious traditions, but still being practiced at least up to the 1970s, patients – mainly women – began with prayers and chanting, then entered a possession state to speak to the prophetess or her female assistant. The first goal was to identify the spirit and then to reveal why it had been troubling a person or working with witches, and to determine the offering or sacrifice that would restore the patient to good health. Rituals ended with a communal sharing of "Madame Tani's holy water." On Fridays, the day of healing, women directed and presided over ritual activity. In a pattern common to many churches, on Sundays educated younger men directed more conventional Western-style prayer services, though these services ended with Fante lyrics and chants, dancing processions, and testimonials about healing work.

Religion and nationalism

Among the most controversial and successful postwar religious figures, at least initially, was Alice Lenshina Mulenga, who began the Lumpa Church in Zambia in 1953 after undergoing a near-death experience in which she claimed to have met Jesus Christ. Her assumed name, Lenshina, came from the Bemba form of "Regina," or Queen. Unlike many other local churches, women and men were completely equal in handling church matters. With Lenshina as their model, women moved from earlier positions as local religious leaders to a religion

https://doi.org/10.1017/CBO9780511979972.006 Published online by Cambridge University Press

with universal appeal. Followers came from all over Zambia and neighboring countries to be baptized, leading to a movement estimated at 60,000 to 100,000 at its peak – a following that exceeded the combined membership of the Catholic and Protestant missions.

As in many other independent churches, women were attracted by policies that allowed widows freedom either to remarry men of their choice, or not to remarry at all. The movement also developed new forms of social morality that supported mothers and motherhood, with commandments that prohibited polygamy and banned drinking and smoking. Both were perceived as male habits that squandered women's resources. Lenshina's aim was to create heaven on earth by eradicating the sin of witchcraft. When people came to her temple, she or her agents dispensed medicines to insure health, fertility, and bountiful harvests. While clearly Christian in its belief in Jesus Christ, Lumpa followers also borrowed deeply from the symbols and images of earlier Bemba initiation ceremonies, restoring women's roles as religious intermediaries. By the late 1950s, their rejection of conventional initiation rituals led to increasing numbers of unmarried mothers in the church.

Although women had their own reasons for joining the new church, some young men found it a useful vehicle for political agitation against the colonial government. As more explicitly political outlets developed in the late 1950s, a cleavage emerged between the supporters of the main nationalist movement, the United National Independence Party (UNIP), many of them men, and more devoted Lenshina followers, disproportionately women. Through the late 1950s, the Lumpa relationship with political authorities deteriorated, first with the colonial administration and then, increasingly, with the UNIP and the chiefs, who were threatened by Lenshina's popularity and spiritual authority. In July 1964, just prior to independence – in the interim period when the UNIP controlled the government, but British officials still managed the security forces – open conflict erupted when Lumpa followers refused to abandon the independent villages they had founded to protect themselves from UNIP violence. Over the next two months, at least 1,000 people died in military attacks and starvation as Lumpa followers fled into the bush. Tension also stemmed from widespread resentment at a woman having more support than the messianic nationalist leader, Kenneth Kaunda. One man interviewed many years later reported:

https://doi.org/10.1017/CBO9780511979972.006 Published online by Cambridge University Press

> All of these people were annoyed and could not understand why people were following a woman … So it was a tug-of-war … UNIP wanted everybody to support them so they could win the elections … But she had her own principles. "I can't worship God and work for the party," she said. That brought a lot of trouble because she refused to be part of UNIP. She only taught the gospel.[23]

In the wake of the violence, Lenshina surrendered on August 11, 1964 in exchange for guarantees of her personal safety. She suffered the next eleven years in detention.

Conclusion

The distressing history of the Lumpa Church highlights the ambiguities of nationalism for some women. Yet, not all women shared the position of Lenshina's followers, nor did the prevalent ideologies of domesticity deter them from political action. Indeed, as Africans became more vocal and assertive in protesting colonial policies and demanding self-government, many women justified their involvement in anticolonial struggles as a way of caring for their families. Challenging privatized European views of home life, they often cited their responsibilities as mothers to justify their political engagement. These women contributed to nationalist movements in important ways, transforming the widely accepted narrative that independence movements were the product of an elite group of Western-educated men.

[23] David M. Gordon, *Invisible Agents: Spirits in a Central African History* (Athens, OH: Ohio University Press, 2012) 137.

https://doi.org/10.1017/CBO9780511979972.006 Published online by Cambridge University Press